

Imperial DoLS GTA Allocator

Guide for Practical/Course Directors

Overview

The GTA Allocator helps match PhD students to practical demonstrating sessions based on their preferences and expertise. This guide explains how to add your practicals and view allocations.

Website: https://tonysouthall.github.io/GTA_allocator/

Accessing the Admin Interface

1. Go to the GTA Allocator website
2. Click **"Convenor View"** in the top right
3. Enter your convenor password (*convenor2026#*) when prompted
4. You'll see the Convenor Dashboard

Note: The Convenor Dashboard lets you add, edit, and delete your practicals, and view student submissions. Running the allocation, sending allocation emails, managing vetoes, and clearing data are now handled centrally by the DPS through a separate DPS-only login - you don't need to (and can't) do these yourself. If you need any of these, contact the DPS.

Adding Your Practical

IMPORTANT: Add Practical Early!

Please add your practical details as soon as possible.

Why this matters:

- Students rank ALL available practicals in order of preference
- If your practical is added late, students may have already used their top preferences
- Early listing = better chance of getting well-matched, enthusiastic GTAs

Step-by-Step: Adding a Practical

In the Admin Dashboard, find the "Add Practical" section and fill in the details:

Field	What to enter
Practical Name	Clear, descriptive name (e.g., "Genetics Lab - PCR Techniques")
Course Code	Module code for pay claims (e.g., "BIOL50001")
Practical Date	When the practical runs
Session Times	Enter a Morning session, an Afternoon session, or both (for a full day with a lunch break). Students see these times and the total hours before signing up.
Signup Deadline	When students must submit preferences by
GTA Slots	Number of demonstrators needed
 Handbook URL	Link to practical handbook using a OneDrive link (share settings: available for IC users, review only). This is REQUIRED — students must read the handbook before their practical.
Convenor Email	Your email address — you will receive the GTA list automatically!

Expertise Tags: Select any relevant tags to help match students with appropriate experience. Need a different tag? Contact the DPS to have one added.

Multi-Day Practicals

If your practical runs over multiple days, please add a separate entry for each day rather than one entry covering the whole block. This allows different students to be allocated to different days, spreading opportunities more fairly, rather than the same one or two GTAs covering the entire practical.

When adding each day:

- Use the same Course Code, Handbook URL, and Convenor Email across all entries
- Distinguish each entry in the Practical Name (e.g. "*Genetics Lab - Day 1*", "*Genetics Lab - Day 2*")

Tips for Good Practical Listings

- Use clear, specific names (not just "Week 3 Practical")
- Include the course code - students need this for pay claims
- Always provide a handbook link - students are expected to read it before the practical
- Enter your convenor email to receive the GTA list automatically
- Enter accurate Session Times — students see this as the advertised session length, and it sets their expectations for how many hours they'll be paid for

Special Circumstances for GTA Allocation

Specialised Allocation Requests

For specialist practicals where particular expertise or experience is needed, convenors may hand-pick a specific student(s) as a GTA(s). To keep this fair and to give other students a training opportunity, at least one additional GTA slot on that practical must still be filled through the normal GTA Allocator process rather than all slots being hand-picked.

Mature Students as GTAs

PhD students who are mature or returning students, or who are engaged in activities such as field courses during the term, may be eligible to serve as GTAs in specific circumstances. This requires agreement from both the student and the relevant Course Director, provided it would not negatively impact their degree. Please contact the DPS (James/Rozan in PhD Ops) if you wish to discuss this for a specific student. The relevant contacts are: James Ferguson/ Rozan Hamilton Nixon - PhD Ops

GTA Eligibility: DoLS Students Only

Only PhD students registered in the Department of Life Sciences (DoLS) are eligible to GTA for departmental practicals. Students from other departments are not eligible to sign up through the Allocator.

Vetoing a Specific Student

In specific circumstances (for example, where it is known that the student taking their responsibilities as a GTA seriously), a staff member may request that a specific student not be allocated to their practical sessions. To request a veto:

- Contact the DPS directly with the student email, your convenor email, and the reason
- Vetoes are applied in the allocation system before the algorithm runs

- This information is treated confidentially

After the Allocation

You Will Receive an Email

Once the DPS runs the allocation, you will automatically receive an email containing:

- Names and email addresses of your allocated GTAs
- Reserve GTAs (2 per practical) — contact these if a main GTA is unavailable
- Practical date and course code

Reserve GTAs

The system automatically allocates 2 reserve GTAs for each practical. These are students who selected your practical as a preference but were not allocated as a main GTA. If one of your main GTAs cannot attend, contact a reserve GTA to step in.

GTA Ratings

After the practical, GTAs are invited to rate their experience. Ratings and comments are visible to the DPS in the Admin Dashboard. You may be contacted if significant feedback is provided about your practical.

Rating Your GTAs

After the practical, you will also receive an automatic email inviting you to rate each of your GTAs individually (1–5 stars, plus an optional comment). This is optional. Ratings are visible only to the DPS — not to other convenors, and not to the GTAs themselves — and may help inform future allocation decisions if a consistent pattern emerges over time.

GTA Pay and Prepwork

GTAs are not paid for time spent preparing for a practical unless you, as the convenor, have agreed this with them in advance. If you expect GTAs to complete preparation beyond reading the handbook, please agree and communicate any paid prep time directly with your GTAs before the practical.

Reporting the Actual Practical Duration

When adding a practical, you'll enter advertised Session Times - students see this before signing up. After each practical has run, please also report back to the DPS how long the session actually lasted. This helps ensure GTA pay claims accurately reflect time worked, particularly if a session runs shorter or longer than advertised.

GTAs and Summative Marking

GTAs should not be asked to carry out summative marking. Their role is to support students during the practical session; any summative assessment of student work remains the responsibility of academic staff.

Editing or Deleting Practicals

To Edit: Find your practical in the list, click "Edit", make changes, click "Save Changes"

To Delete: Find your practical, click "Delete", confirm when prompted

About the Allocation

Do not run the allocation yourself unless instructed by DPS

The allocation should be run centrally by the DPS to ensure all practicals for the term have been added and all deadlines have passed.

How the algorithm works:

- Equal distribution - everyone gets one slot before anyone gets a second
- Priority to students with fewer previous hours — fair opportunity for all
- Respects preferences - tries to give everyone their top choices
- Reserve allocation - 2 backup GTAs assigned per practical
- Vetoed students - automatically excluded from the relevant convenor's practicals

Recommended Timeline

When	Action
Start of term	Add all known practicals for the term
Once all practicals added & preferences submitted	Allocation run by DPS
After allocation	You receive email with GTA list

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: How do I know which students have been allocated to my practical?

A: You will receive an automatic email with the names and email addresses of your GTAs (including reserves) after the allocation is run.

Q: What if a GTA can't make it on the day?

A: Contact one of your reserve GTAs — their details are included in your allocation email.

Q: I didn't receive the allocation email — what should I do?

A: Check your spam/junk folder. If it's not there, verify the convenor email address is correct in your practical listing, or contact DPS.

Q: What if not enough students selected my practical?

A: Contact DPS — they may be able to help recruit additional GTAs or suggest alternatives.

Q: Can I request that a student not be assigned to my practical?

A: Yes. Contact the DPS to request a veto for exceptional circumstances (e.g. supervisory relationships). The veto is applied confidentially before the allocation runs.

Q: A mature student has approached me about being a GTA for my practical — is that allowed?

A: Potentially yes, in specific circumstances, provided both you and the student agree and it would not impact their degree. Please contact the DPS.

Need Help?

Contact the Director of Postgraduate Studies:
Tony Southall — t.southall@imperial.ac.uk